

Zero to Google: DSA, System Design and Test Engineering for QA Engineers

Volume 4 - English for technical interviews

Written for Sahil Sharma - SDET preparing for Google SWE-Test / SDET (India). Study it with the web app <https://sahil804-ps.github.io/google-prep/> and Google NotebookLM.

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Grammar 1: Present simple vs present continuous

- Present simple = habits, facts: "I **write** test cases every day."
- Present continuous = right now / temporary: "I **am writing** a test right now."
- Stative verbs (know, have, want, believe) are NOT used in -ing: "I **know** Python", not "I am knowing".

Hindi tip: Hum aksar "I am having 5 years experience" bolte hain - galat. "have" possession hai, -ing nahi lagta.

Quiz

1. I ___ 5 years of experience in testing.
 - A) am having
 - B) have
 - C) having
2. Right now I ___ on an API automation project.
 - A) work
 - B) am working
 - C) worked
3. She ___ Selenium very well.
 - A) is knowing
 - B) knows
 - C) know
4. Our CI pipeline ___ every night at 2 AM.
 - A) runs
 - B) is running
 - C) run

Answer key

1. **B** - have. have = possession, no -ing.
2. **B** - am working. Temporary / current activity.
3. **B** - knows. know is stative; third person -s.
4. **A** - runs. Schedule / habit = present simple.

Grammar 2: Past simple vs present perfect

- Past simple = finished time: "I **joined** Antier in 2020."
- Present perfect = experience / result now, no specific time: "I **have worked** on blockchain testing."
- With "since / for" until now: "I **have been** at Antier **since** 2020."

Hindi tip: Agar time bataya (yesterday, in 2020, last year) to past simple. "I have done it yesterday" galat hai.

Quiz

1. I ___ the bug yesterday.
 - A) have found
 - B) found
 - C) find
2. I ___ at Antier since 2020.
 - A) work
 - B) worked
 - C) have worked
3. ___ you ever used Playwright?
 - A) Did
 - B) Have
 - C) Do
4. We ___ the release last Friday.
 - A) shipped
 - B) have shipped
 - C) ship

Answer key

1. **B** - found. Specific past time -> past simple.
2. **C** - have worked. since + until now -> present perfect.
3. **B** - Have. Experience question -> present perfect.
4. **A** - shipped. last Friday = finished time.

Grammar 3: Articles: a, an, the

- a/an = one of many, first mention: "I found **a** bug."
- an before a vowel SOUND: "**an** API", "**an** hour", but "**a** user".
- the = specific / already known: "**The** bug was in the login module."
- No article for general plural/uncountable: "Tests are important."

Hindi tip: Hindi mein article nahi hota, isliye hum chhod dete hain. "I found bug" -> "I found a bug".

Quiz

1. I wrote ___ automation framework in Python.
 - A) a
 - B) an
 - C) the
2. ___ user could not log in.
 - A) An
 - B) A
 - C) The (first mention)
3. I fixed a bug. ___ bug was in the payment module.
 - A) A
 - B) The
 - C) -
4. It took ___ hour to run the suite.
 - A) a
 - B) an
 - C) the

Answer key

1. **B** - an. "automation" starts with a vowel sound.
2. **B** - A. "user" sounds like "you-ser" -> a.
3. **B** - The. Second mention -> the.
4. **B** - an. "hour" has a silent h -> an.

Grammar 4: Prepositions: in, on, at

- Time: **at** 5 PM, **on** Monday, **in** October / **in** 2026
- Place: **at** the office, **in** Mohali, **on** the dashboard / **on** GitHub
- Work: work **on** a project, work **at/for** a company, work **in** a team

Hindi tip: "I am working in Antier" -> "I work at Antier". "discuss about" galat hai - sirf "discuss".

Quiz

1. The interview is ___ Monday ___ 11 AM.
 - A) in / at
 - B) on / at
 - C) at / on
2. I work ___ Antier Solutions.
 - A) in
 - B) at
 - C) on
3. The code is ___ GitHub.
 - A) in
 - B) at
 - C) on
4. Let us ___ the test plan.
 - A) discuss about
 - B) discuss
 - C) discuss on

Answer key

1. **B** - on / at. on + day, at + clock time.
2. **B** - at. work at a company.
3. **C** - on. on a platform/website.
4. **B** - discuss. discuss takes no preposition.

Grammar 5: Questions without mistakes

- Yes/no: auxiliary first: "**Do** you use Jira?" "**Is** the build green?"
- Wh-: "**What does** this function return?" (not "What this function returns?")
- Indirect questions keep normal order: "Can you tell me **what the input size is**?"

Hindi tip: Clarifying questions interview mein bahut important hain. "What is the input size?" ya "Can I assume the input is sorted?"

Quiz

1. ___ the input always sorted?
 - A) Does
 - B) Is
 - C) Are
2. What ___ the function return for an empty list?
 - A) does
 - B) do
 - C) is
3. Can you tell me how big ___?
 - A) is the input
 - B) the input is
 - C) input is
4. ___ I assume there are no duplicates?
 - A) Can
 - B) Am
 - C) Do

Answer key

1. **B** - Is. is + adjective.
2. **A** - does. third person singular -> does.
3. **B** - the input is. Indirect question keeps normal order.
4. **A** - Can. Asking permission / assumption -> Can/May.

Grammar 6: Explaining code: sequence words

- **First**, I will ... **Then** ... **After that** ... **Finally** ...
- "I iterate over the array **and** for each element I check ..."
- "**If** the map contains the complement, **then** I return the indexes; **otherwise** I add the element."

Hindi tip: Interview mein code ke saath bolna zaroori hai. Short sentences + sequence words se clear lagta hai.

Quiz

1. ___, I will sort the array. Then I will use two pointers.
 - A) Finally
 - B) First
 - C) Otherwise
2. If the sum is too small, I move the left pointer; ___, I move the right one.
 - A) otherwise
 - B) first
 - C) because
3. ___, I return the result.
 - A) Finally
 - B) Firstly then
 - C) Since
4. I use a hash map ___ lookups are $O(1)$.
 - A) so
 - B) because
 - C) but

Answer key

1. **B** - First. Starting a sequence.
2. **A** - otherwise. otherwise = else.
3. **A** - Finally. Last step.
4. **B** - because. Giving a reason.

Grammar 7: Talking about complexity

- "The time complexity **is** $O(n)$ **because** we visit each element once."
- "The space complexity is $O(n)$ **for** the hash map."
- "This is **linear / logarithmic / quadratic** time."
- "We could **trade** space **for** time."

Hindi tip: Complexity bolte waqt hamesha "because" ke saath reason do.

Quiz

1. $O(n^2)$ is called ___ time.
 - A) linear
 - B) quadratic
 - C) constant
2. $O(\log n)$ is called ___ time.
 - A) logarithmic
 - B) linear
 - C) exponential
3. The space is $O(n)$ ___ the hash map.
 - A) for
 - B) from
 - C) at
4. We trade space ___ time.
 - A) to
 - B) for
 - C) with

Answer key

1. **B** - quadratic. n squared = quadratic.
2. **A** - logarithmic. $\log n$ = logarithmic.
3. **A** - for. "for" + what uses the space.
4. **B** - for. trade X for Y.

Grammar 8: Modal verbs: can, could, should, would, might

- **can** = ability: "I can automate this."
- **could / might** = possibility, polite: "This could be a race condition."
- **should** = advice: "We should add a boundary test."
- **would** = hypothetical / polite: "I would start with unit tests."

Hindi tip: Interview mein "I would..." bahut useful hai: "I would first clarify the requirements."

Quiz

1. I ___ start by asking about the input size.
 - A) would
 - B) will be
 - C) am
2. The test fails sometimes. It ___ be a timing issue.
 - A) must to
 - B) might
 - C) should to
3. We ___ add tests for empty input.
 - A) should
 - B) should to
 - C) must to
4. ___ you repeat the question, please?
 - A) Can to
 - B) Could
 - C) Should

Answer key

1. **A** - would. Polite hypothetical plan.
2. **B** - might. Possibility.
3. **A** - should. Modal + base verb (no "to").
4. **B** - Could. Polite request.

Grammar 9: Conditionals (if)

- Zero: facts: "If the input **is** empty, the function **returns** 0."
- First: real future: "If I **have** time, I **will optimise** it."
- Second: hypothetical: "If I **had** more memory, I **would use** a cache."

Hindi tip: "If I will get time" galat hai - if ke baad will nahi aata.

Quiz

1. If the list ___ empty, return None.
 - A) is
 - B) will be
 - C) would be
2. If I ___ more time, I would add caching.
 - A) have
 - B) had
 - C) will have
3. If the build fails, I ___ the logs.
 - A) check
 - B) will checked
 - C) would checked
4. If I get the offer, I ___ relocate.
 - A) will
 - B) would had
 - C) am

Answer key

1. **A** - is. Zero/first conditional: present after if.
2. **B** - had. Second conditional.
3. **A** - check. Fact / routine.
4. **A** - will. First conditional.

Grammar 10: Passive voice for technical writing

- Active: "I fixed the bug." Passive: "The bug **was fixed**."
- Use passive when the action matters more than the person: "Tests **are run** on every commit."
- In interviews, prefer ACTIVE for your own work: "I designed..." (shows ownership).

Hindi tip: Behavioral answers mein "I" use karo, "it was done" nahi - credit lo.

Quiz

1. Tests ___ on every pull request.
 - A) run
 - B) are run
 - C) is run
2. The issue ___ last week.
 - A) was fixed
 - B) fixed
 - C) is fix
3. Better for a behavioural answer:
 - A) The framework was built.
 - B) I built the framework.
 - C) Framework built.
4. The report ___ automatically every morning.
 - A) generates
 - B) is generated
 - C) generated

Answer key

1. **B** - are run. Plural passive present.
2. **A** - was fixed. Passive past.
3. **B** - I built the framework.. Active shows ownership.
4. **B** - is generated. Report does not generate itself.

Grammar 11: Common Indian-English mistakes

(1)

- "Do the needful" -> "Please take care of this"
- "Revert back" -> "Reply" (revert = go back to old state)
- "Prepone" -> "Move earlier"
- "I have a doubt" -> "I have a question"
- "Out of station" -> "Out of town / travelling"

Hindi tip: Ye India mein chalte hain, par global interview mein clear English better hai.

Quiz

1. Better: "Please ___ by Friday."
 - A) revert back
 - B) reply
 - C) revert
2. Better: "I have a ___ about the requirement."
 - A) doubt
 - B) question
 - C) query back
3. Better: "Can we ___ the meeting?"
 - A) prepone
 - B) move earlier
 - C) pre-move
4. Better: "I will be ___ next week."
 - A) out of station
 - B) travelling
 - C) out station

Answer key

1. **B** - reply. revert means undo.
2. **B** - question. doubt = suspicion in global English.
3. **B** - move earlier. prepone is Indian English.
4. **B** - travelling. Clear for global audience.

Grammar 12: Common Indian-English mistakes

(2)

- "I am having a question" -> "I have a question"
- "He is working here since 2 years" -> "He has been working here for 2 years"
- "Myself Sahil" -> "I am Sahil" / "My name is Sahil"
- "Kindly do it fast" -> "Could you please prioritise this?"

Hindi tip: "Myself Sahil" interview ke shuru mein mat bolna. "Hi, I am Sahil" bolo.

Quiz

1. Best introduction:
 - A) Myself Sahil.
 - B) I am Sahil.
 - C) Me Sahil.
2. He has been working here ___ 2 years.
 - A) since
 - B) for
 - C) from
3. I ___ a question about the API.
 - A) am having
 - B) have
 - C) having
4. Since ___ I have been testing APIs.
 - A) 3 years
 - B) 2021
 - C) long time

Answer key

1. **B** - I am Sahil.. Natural introduction.
2. **B** - for. for + duration, since + start point.
3. **B** - have. Stative have.
4. **B** - 2021. since + point in time.

Grammar 13: Comparatives and superlatives

- short: fast -> faster -> the fastest
- long: efficient -> more efficient -> the most efficient
- irregular: good -> better -> best; bad -> worse -> worst
- "This approach is **more efficient than** brute force."

Hindi tip: "more faster" galat hai - double comparative mat lagao.

Quiz

1. A hash map is ___ than a list for lookups.
 - A) more faster
 - B) faster
 - C) fastest
2. This is the ___ solution so far.
 - A) most efficient
 - B) more efficient
 - C) efficientest
3. The second approach is ___ than the first.
 - A) gooder
 - B) better
 - C) more good
4. Brute force is ___ for large inputs.
 - A) worse
 - B) badder
 - C) more bad

Answer key

1. **B** - faster. One comparative only.
2. **A** - most efficient. Long adjective superlative.
3. **B** - better. Irregular.
4. **A** - worse. Irregular.

Grammar 14: Linking words: however, although, therefore

- **However** (contrast, new sentence): "It is fast. However, it uses more memory."
- **Although** (contrast, same sentence): "Although it is fast, it uses more memory."
- **Therefore / So** (result): "The input is sorted, so I will use binary search."

Hindi tip: Trade-offs explain karne ke liye perfect: "It is faster; however, it needs extra space."

Quiz

1. It is $O(n)$. ___, it needs $O(n)$ extra space.
 - A) However
 - B) Although
 - C) Because
2. ___ the test passed locally, it failed in CI.
 - A) However
 - B) Although
 - C) Therefore
3. The array is sorted; ___, binary search works.
 - A) therefore
 - B) although
 - C) however
4. "Although ... but ..." is:
 - A) Correct
 - B) Wrong - use only one
 - C) Formal

Answer key

1. **A** - However. Contrast, new sentence.
2. **B** - Although. Contrast in one sentence.
3. **A** - therefore. Result.
4. **B** - Wrong - use only one. Do not use both.

Grammar 15: Reported speech in stories

- Direct: The PM said, "We **need** it today."
- Reported: The PM said (that) we **needed** it that day.
- "My manager asked me **to** lead the testing." / "He told me **that** the release **was** delayed."

Hindi tip: Behavioral stories mein bahut kaam aata hai: "My manager asked me to..."

Quiz

1. My manager asked me ___ the regression suite.
 - A) own
 - B) to own
 - C) owning
2. He said that the build ___ broken.
 - A) is been
 - B) was
 - C) were
3. She told ___ the deadline had moved.
 - A) to me
 - B) me
 - C) at me
4. He ___ that the fix was ready.
 - A) said me
 - B) said
 - C) told

Answer key

1. **B** - to own. ask someone to do.
2. **B** - was. Backshift in reported speech.
3. **B** - me. tell someone (no "to").
4. **B** - said. say + that; tell + person.

Grammar 16: Countable vs uncountable

- Uncountable (no -s): information, feedback, advice, equipment, software, code, data (usually)
- "a lot of feedback", "a piece of advice", "some code"
- Countable: bug(s), test(s), issue(s): "many bugs", "few tests"

Hindi tip: "Feedbacks", "softwares", "codes" galat hain.

Quiz

1. Thank you for the ____.
 - A) feedbacks
 - B) feedback
 - C) a feedback
2. We found ____ bugs in this release.
 - A) much
 - B) many
 - C) a
3. I wrote some ____ for the parser.
 - A) codes
 - B) code
 - C) a code
4. Can I give you a piece of ____?
 - A) advice
 - B) advices
 - C) advise

Answer key

1. **B** - feedback. feedback is uncountable.
2. **B** - many. bugs are countable.
3. **B** - code. code (programming) is uncountable.
4. **A** - advice. advice = noun, uncountable.

Grammar 17: Gerunds and infinitives

- Verb + -ing: enjoy, avoid, finish, suggest, consider: "I enjoy **debugging**."
- Verb + to: want, decide, plan, hope, need: "I decided **to automate** it."
- "I am looking forward **to working** with you." (to + -ing here)

Hindi tip: "Looking forward to hear" galat hai -> "looking forward to hearing".

Quiz

1. I enjoy ___ complex bugs.
 - A) to solve
 - B) solving
 - C) solve
2. We decided ___ Playwright.
 - A) using
 - B) to use
 - C) use
3. I look forward to ___ from you.
 - A) hear
 - B) hearing
 - C) heard
4. I suggest ___ a retry.
 - A) adding
 - B) to add
 - C) add

Answer key

1. **B** - solving. enjoy + -ing.
2. **B** - to use. decide + to.
3. **B** - hearing. look forward to + -ing.
4. **A** - adding. suggest + -ing.

Grammar 18: Polite language for disagreements

- "I see your point, but have we considered ...?"
- "That makes sense. One concern I have is ..."
- "Could we try ... and measure the result?"
- Avoid: "You are wrong", "That is not possible".

Hindi tip: Googleyness = respectful disagreement. Data aur user ka focus rakho.

Quiz

1. Most collaborative:
 - A) You are wrong.
 - B) I see your point, but one concern is...
 - C) No, that will not work.
2. Polite suggestion:
 - A) Do it my way.
 - B) Could we try a small experiment?
 - C) Just change it.
3. Asking for clarity:
 - A) What you mean?
 - B) Could you clarify what you mean by...?
 - C) Explain.
4. Admitting uncertainty:
 - A) I don't know.
 - B) I am not sure, but my guess is... and I would verify by...
 - C) No idea.

Answer key

1. **B** - I see your point, but one concern is.... Acknowledge then add your view.
2. **B** - Could we try a small experiment?. Suggest, do not order.
3. **B** - Could you clarify what you mean by...?. Polite + correct order.
4. **B** - I am not sure, but my guess is... and I would verify by.... Show how you would find out.

Grammar 19: Pronunciation: tech words

- **cache** = "cash" (not "catch-ee")
- **queue** = "kyoo"
- **SQL** = "S-Q-L" or "sequel"
- **Linux** = "LIN-ux"
- **data** = "DAY-ta" or "DAA-ta" (both OK)
- **algorithm** = "AL-go-ri-thum"
- **async** = "AY-sink"

Hindi tip: Har word ko YouTube pe "how to pronounce X" search karke suno, phir 5 baar bolo.

Quiz

1. "cache" sounds like:
 - A) catch
 - B) cash
 - C) ka-chay
2. "queue" sounds like:
 - A) kyoo
 - B) kway-way
 - C) q-u-e
3. Stress in "algorithm" is on:
 - A) AL
 - B) GO
 - C) RITHM
4. "async" is said:
 - A) ay-sink
 - B) a-sync-k
 - C) ass-ink

Answer key

1. **B** - cash. Same as money "cash".
2. **A** - kyoo. Just the letter Q.
3. **A** - AL. AL-go-rithm.
4. **A** - ay-sink. AY-sink.

Grammar 20: Talking about numbers and impact

- "We **reduced** regression time **from** 6 hours **to** 2 hours."
- "Test coverage **increased by** 20 percent."
- "**Around / roughly** 200 test cases."
- Only use numbers you can defend in the interview.

Hindi tip: Impact ko numbers mein bolo, par sirf sach wale numbers.

Quiz

1. We reduced the run time ___ 6 hours ___ 2 hours.
 - A) from / to
 - B) by / to
 - C) to / from
2. Coverage increased ___ 20 percent.
 - A) with
 - B) by
 - C) of
3. For an estimate, say:
 - A) exactly 213.6
 - B) roughly 200
 - C) many many
4. Bugs ___ by half after the change.
 - A) dropped
 - B) were drop
 - C) dropping

Answer key

1. **A** - from / to. from X to Y.
2. **B** - by. increase by an amount.
3. **B** - roughly 200. Natural estimate.
4. **A** - dropped. Past simple verb.

Grammar 21: Thinking aloud in a coding interview

- "Let me make sure I understand the problem ..."
- "A brute-force approach would be ..., which is $O(n^2)$. Can we do better?"
- "I am thinking of using ... because ..."
- "Let me walk through an example to verify."
- "I think there is an edge case when ..."

Hindi tip: Silence sabse bada problem hai. Har 20-30 second mein bolte raho kya soch rahe ho.

Quiz

1. Best opening:
 - A) Starts coding immediately
 - B) Let me make sure I understand the problem...
 - C) This is easy.
2. After brute force, say:
 - A) Done.
 - B) Can we do better?
 - C) That is the answer.
3. Before finishing, you should:
 - A) Walk through an example
 - B) Stay silent
 - C) Delete comments
4. If stuck, say:
 - A) I give up.
 - B) Let me think about which data structure helps here...
 - C) ...silence...

Answer key

1. **B** - Let me make sure I understand the problem.... Clarify first.
2. **B** - Can we do better?. Show optimisation thinking.
3. **A** - Walk through an example. Dry run / test.
4. **B** - Let me think about which data structure helps here.... Keep thinking aloud.

Grammar 22: Closing the interview well

- "Thank you, I really enjoyed this problem."
- Questions to ask: "What does a typical day look like for an engineer on this team?", "How does the team handle flaky tests / test infrastructure?", "What would success look like in the first 6 months?"
- Avoid asking about salary in technical rounds.

Hindi tip: Hamesha 2 sawaal ready rakho. "No questions" mat bolo.

Quiz

1. Good question to ask:
 - A) How much leave do I get?
 - B) How does the team decide what to automate?
 - C) Is this round hard?
2. If asked "Any questions?", you should:
 - A) Say no
 - B) Ask 1-2 thoughtful questions
 - C) Ask about salary
3. Closing line:
 - A) Bye.
 - B) Thank you, I enjoyed solving this.
 - C) Did I pass?
4. Best time to discuss salary:
 - A) Coding round
 - B) With the recruiter
 - C) Never

Answer key

1. **B** - How does the team decide what to automate?. Shows interest in the work.
2. **B** - Ask 1-2 thoughtful questions. Always have questions.
3. **B** - Thank you, I enjoyed solving this.. Polite and positive.
4. **B** - With the recruiter. Recruiter conversation.

Interview phrase bank

Say each phrase out loud three times. Use them in mock interviews.

1. Let me make sure I understand the problem correctly.
2. Can I assume the input fits in memory?
3. Could you give me an example input and output?
4. What should happen if the input is empty?
5. A brute-force approach would be to ...
6. This would take $O(n^2)$ time. Can we do better?
7. I am thinking of using a hash map because ...
8. Let me walk through an example to check my logic.
9. I think there is an edge case when ...
10. The trade-off here is time versus space.
11. Let me write a quick test for this.
12. I would start by clarifying the requirements.
13. Before I design tests, I want to understand the users.
14. I would prioritise the tests by risk and impact.
15. For the happy path, I would check ...
16. For boundary cases, I would test ...
17. I would automate this at the unit level because ...
18. This is better covered by an integration test.
19. To reduce flakiness, I would ...
20. I would monitor this in production using ...
21. That is a good point. One concern I have is ...
22. I see what you mean. Have we considered ...?
23. I am not completely sure, but my guess is ...
24. Let me think about that for a moment.
25. Could you repeat the last part, please?
26. In my current role, I am responsible for ...
27. One challenge I faced was ...
28. What I learned from that was ...
29. As a result, the team was able to ...
30. I took ownership of ...
31. I collaborated with the developers to ...
32. The root cause turned out to be ...
33. We reduced the time from ... to ...
34. If I had more time, I would ...
35. To summarise, my approach is ...
36. Thank you, I really enjoyed this discussion.
37. What does success look like for this role?
38. How does the team approach test infrastructure?
39. I am excited about this role because ...

40. I am comfortable working with ambiguity.

Speaking practice prompts

Shadowing: play a 1-minute clip of a clear speaker (e.g. a Google I/O talk or a NeetCode explanation), pause after each sentence and repeat it with the same speed and stress. Do 5 minutes.

Filler words to avoid: *um, umm, uh, basically, actually, like, you know, so yeah, kind of, sort of, literally*

1. Introduce yourself in 75 seconds: role, experience, one achievement, why Google.
2. Explain today's first DSA problem and your approach, as if to an interviewer.
3. Explain the time and space complexity of your last solution and why.
4. Describe your current project at work to someone non-technical.
5. Explain the test pyramid and why it matters.
6. Explain what a flaky test is and how you would deal with it.
7. Tell a STAR story: a critical bug you found.
8. Explain the difference between a mock, a stub and a fake.
9. Describe how you would test a login page.
10. Explain how a hash map works internally.
11. Explain why Google, and why a test engineering role.
12. Explain what CI/CD is to a new joiner.
13. Tell a STAR story: a disagreement and how you resolved it.
14. Explain binary search with an example.
15. Describe qaforge-mcp: what it does and why you built it.
16. Explain how you would design tests for an API rate limiter.
17. Tell a STAR story: something you improved for your team.
18. Explain BFS vs DFS and when to use each.
19. Explain caching and one problem it can cause.
20. Describe your biggest weakness and what you do about it.
21. Explain recursion to a beginner.
22. Describe how you would test Google Maps directions.
23. Tell a STAR story: a failure and what you learned.
24. Explain dynamic programming in simple words.
25. Summarise what you learned this week in 2 minutes.